

[Return to Search](#)

The Hoggar Tuareg

Author(S): Lhote, Henri, Sipfle, Mary-Alice**Document Type:** Book Chapter**Original Page:** 149**Culture (OWC):** [Tuareg \(MS25\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Northern Africa**Field Date:** 1929-1940**Coverage Date:** 1900-1940**Place Coverage:** Algeria**Section Title(S):** Chapter 1 Social Life

The presence of several girls in a camp is often sufficient cause for organizing an ahal mixed with asri. The young men come from neighboring camps, always dressed in their dressy clothes. Some of them sometimes come hundreds of kilometers to attend a meeting where they know they will find pretty girls and pleasant distraction. Then one of those present plays the violin. The sourish, plaintive, monotonous sounds which come out of it are quite in harmony with the wild setting made by nature and man. The men accentuate the rhythm by singing "ho ho" on the beat and finally by a hummed accompaniment. And everyone jokes and tells broad stories, for the poetic part is often of a very doubtful quality, if not made up of more or less vulgar repartee.

[517
Leisure Time Activities](#)[521
Conversation](#)[522
Humor](#)[533
Music](#)[538
Literature](#)[571
Social Relationships
And Groups](#)[574
Visiting And
Hospitality](#)

Then the violin is silent, and laughter bursts out on all sides. Men and women make very free contacts and rub noses which is the peculiar form of the Tuareg kiss. These meetings end very late at night, and everyone returns to his camp, not, however, without having made an appointment by a special

[517
Leisure Time Activities](#)[521
Conversation](#)

language of hand gestures to finish these amorous love feasts in a more intimate way.

533
Music

571
Social Relationships
And Groups

832
Sexual Stimulation

The mores of the girls are indeed very licentious, so much so that Father de Foucault stated that the word "virginity" did not exist in Tamashek.⁽¹⁾ "There is no question of keeping the girl  150 pure until her marriage," said Dr. Vermale elsewhere. "Those are sentiments which the Tuareg do not understand. Thus, as soon as she is nubile, she goes to the ohal and it is not long before she is deflowered. Virginity does not exist and has no representative value in the eyes of the Tuareg."⁽²⁾ Indeed, the women are more or less easy. Some give themselves to the first comer; others grant their favors to only a small group of friends. To grant them only to a single person, however, would be judged in very bad taste and a sign of perversion.

577
Ethics

836
Premarital Sex
Relations

839
Miscellaneous Sex
Behavior

1. Dr. Vermale, [Au Sahara pendant la guerre européenne](#) /In the Sahara During the European War/, p. 172.

2. [Op. cit.](#), p. 171.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)